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Regime Shifts in Plankton Dynamics: What Drives Them and Can We Predict Them?

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www.seewandel.org

Ecomeets @ Eawag, Dübendorf
28 October 2026

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Slides, code and data shared openly
leomarameo7.github.io/science_communication.html

Acknowledgements



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eawag aquatic research

WSL

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Take home message

1. Plankton regime shifts can be detected and partly explained by biotic drivers.

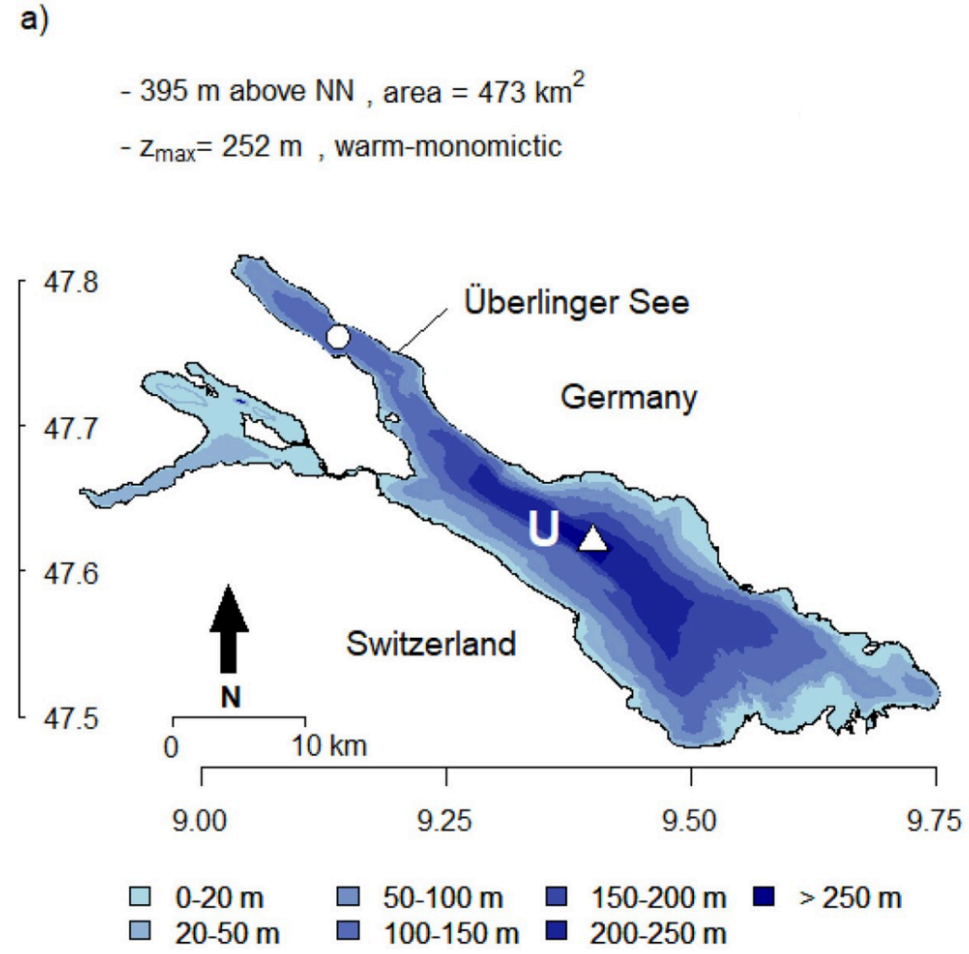
2. Whether they propagate and can be predicted is still open.

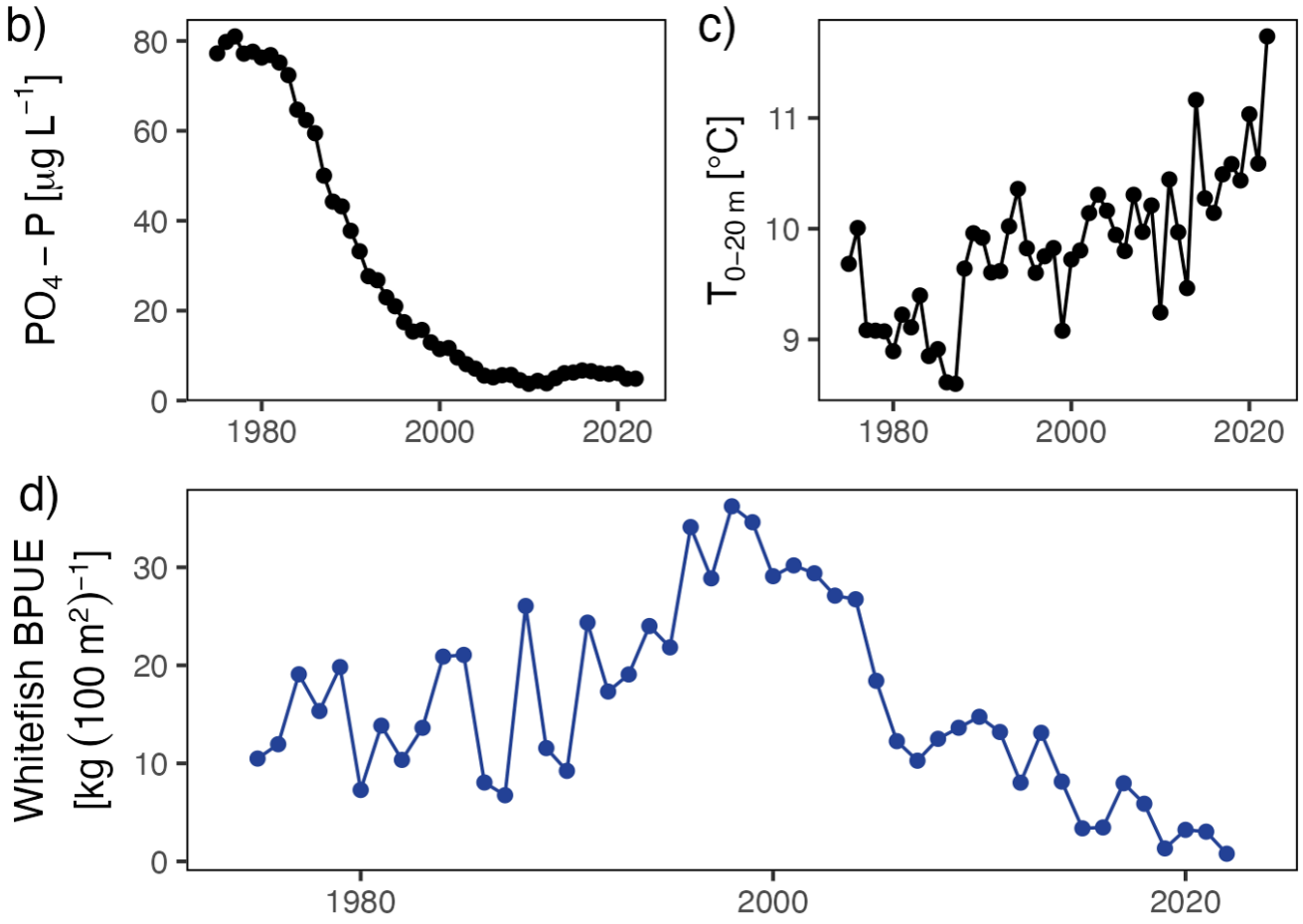


Outline

1. What we know: background
2. Research questions
3. Methods: our pipeline
4. Results: detection of regime shifts
5. Explain regime shifts
6. Propagation of regime shifts
7. Conclusions

What we know: background



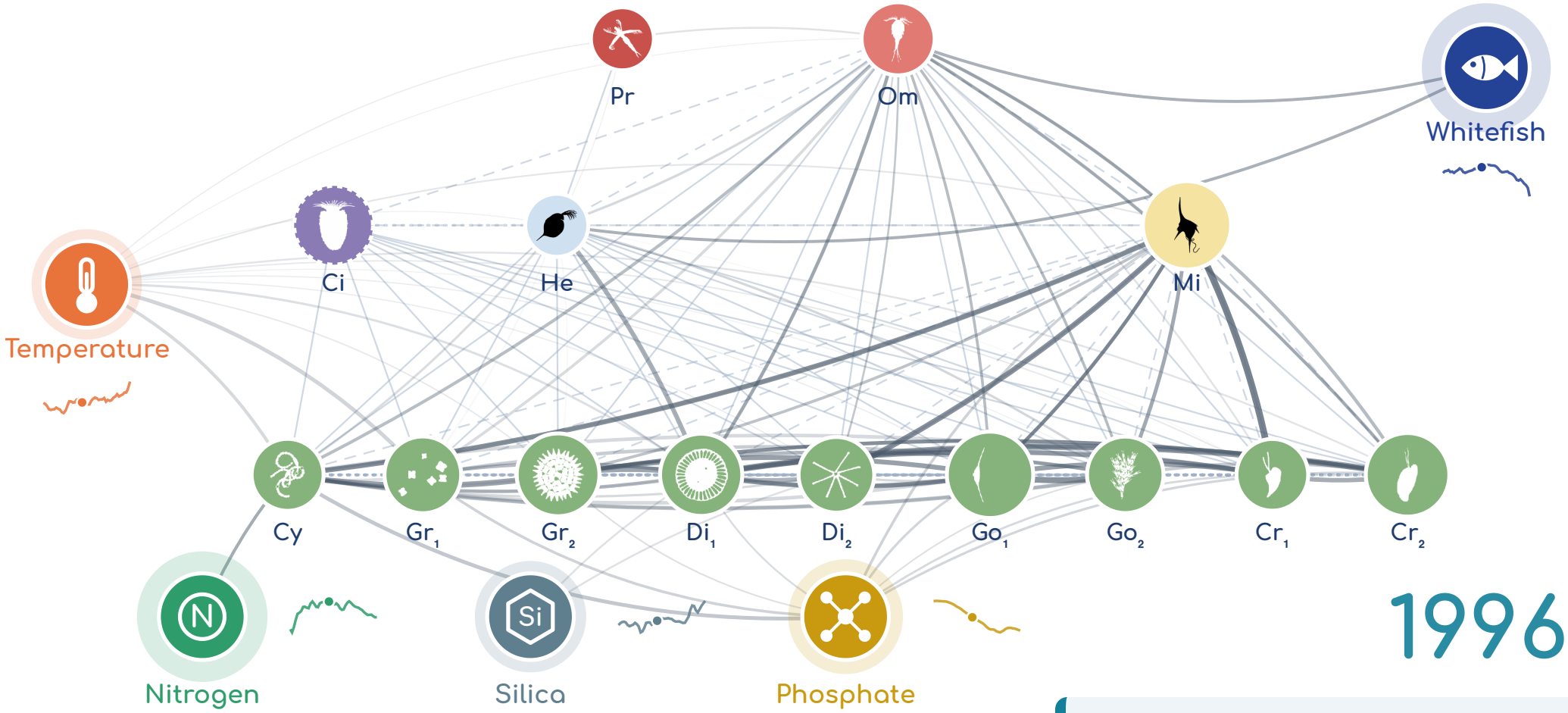


Lake Constance · 473 km²

Phosphate ↑ until 1980, then ↓

Temperature ↑ about 1 °C

What we know: the plankton community



1996

Study period: 1975–2022 · monthly time series

The plankton community changes across time

Network modified from Merz et al. 2023, Nat. Clim. Change.

Research questions



1 · Detect

Abrupt shifts?



2 · Explain

What drives them?



3 · Propagate

Does a shift spread?



4 · Predict

Can we forecast them? (in progress)

Methods: our pipeline

1

Data

Monthly data 1975–2022

2

Detect

BEAST + two criteria

3

Explain

GP-EDM + hypotheses

4

Propagate

Shift-removal test

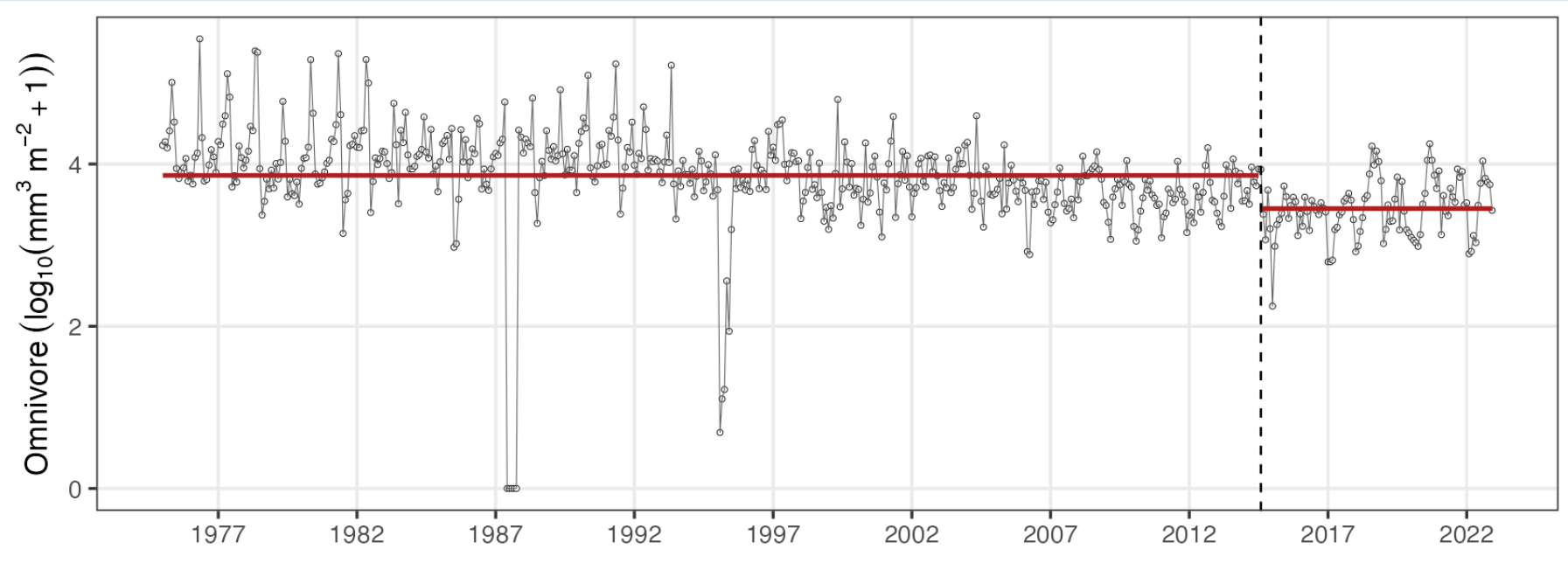
5

Predict

Forward validation

WORK IN PROGRESS

Results: detection of regime shifts



Omnivores, monthly biovolume. Dashed: shift; red: period means.

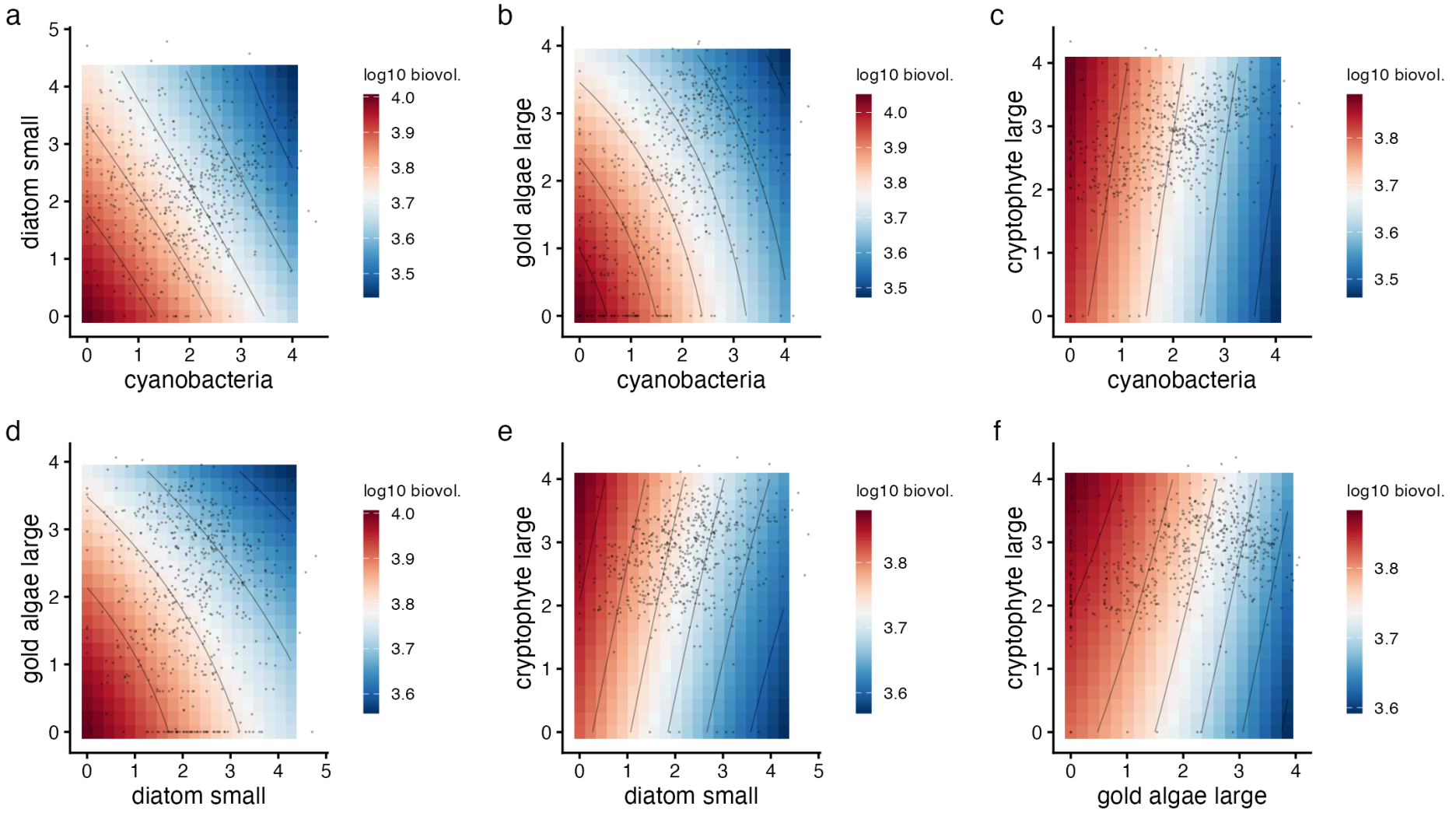


Shift: Aug 2014

abruptness 1.19

The omnivores dropped abruptly in 2014

Explain regime shifts



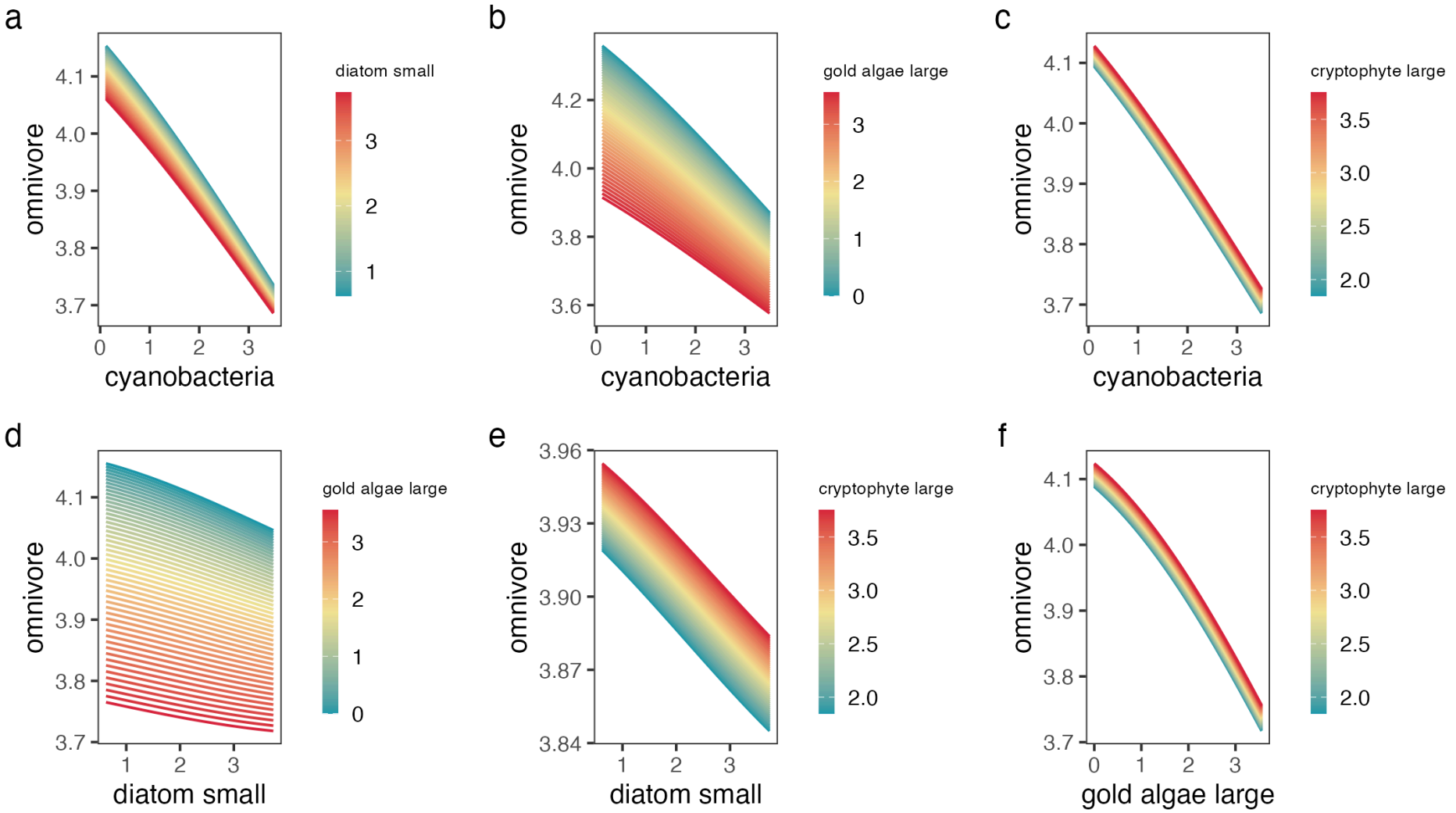


LOO R^2 = **0.81**

Omnivores ↓ with cyanobacteria, small diatoms, large gold algae

Prey hypothesis: **not supported**

Explain regime shifts: partial dependence





x: predictor 1
lines: predictor 2

Cyanobacteria ↓ omnivores

Lines never cross

Propagation of regime shifts

1 · Real predictor



2 candidate pairs

0 testable

Predictor shifted **after**

2 · Shift-free surrogate (× 100)



Gap between real and surrogate prediction = evidence for propagation

No evidence yet: too few shifts

Conclusions



Shifts are detectable



Biotic drivers matter



Propagation, prediction: open

Take home message

1. Plankton regime shifts can be detected and partly explained by biotic drivers.

2. Whether they propagate and can be predicted is still open.



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igkb
Internationale Gewässerschutzkommission für den Bodensee

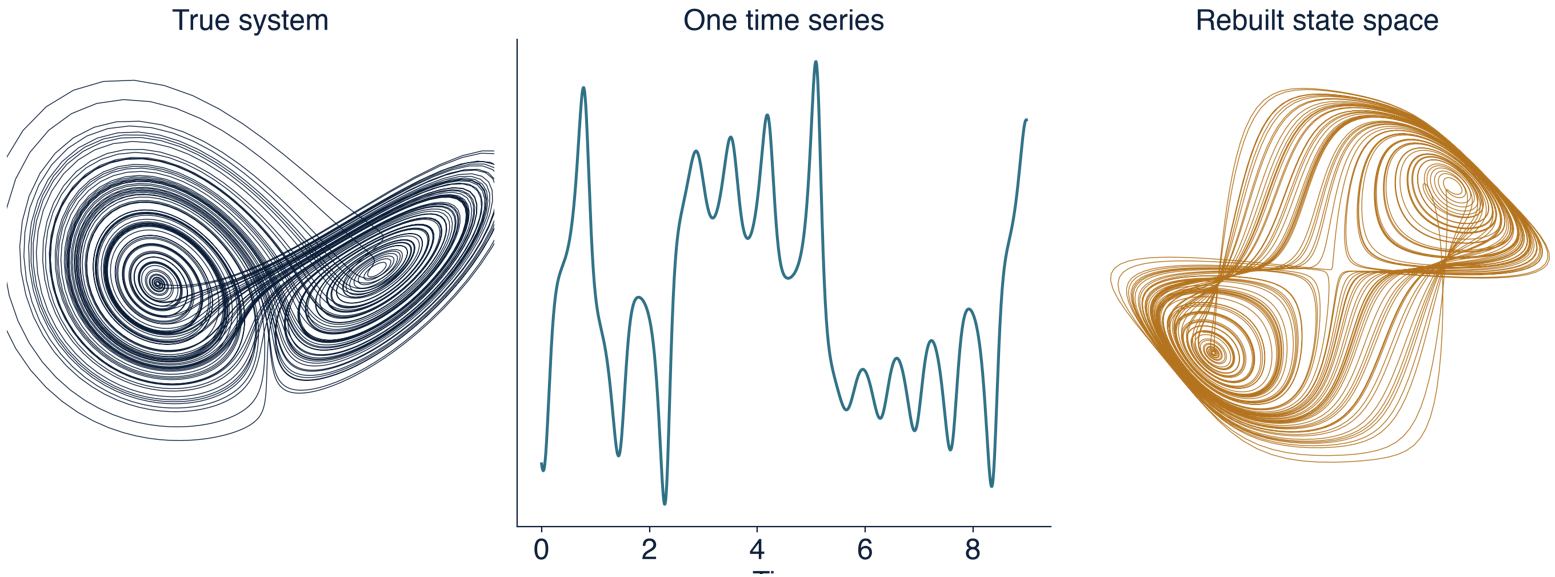
IBKF

SeeWandel-Climate · Pomati lab and colleagues at Eawag
Luis J. Gilarranz · Stefanie Eyring · Stephan B. Munch · Tanya L. Rogers · Francesco Pomati
Data: IGKB, IBKF, University of Konstanz

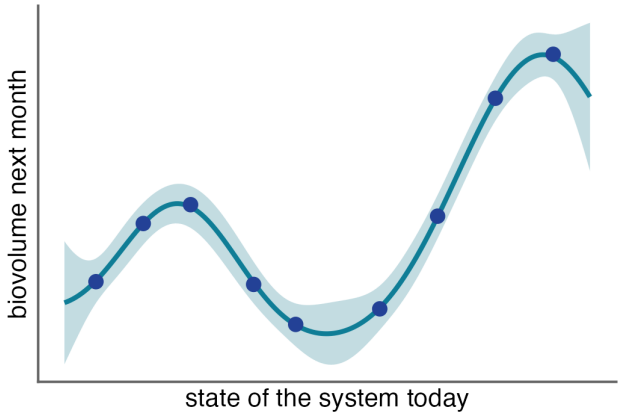
Supplementary materials



What is GP-EDM?



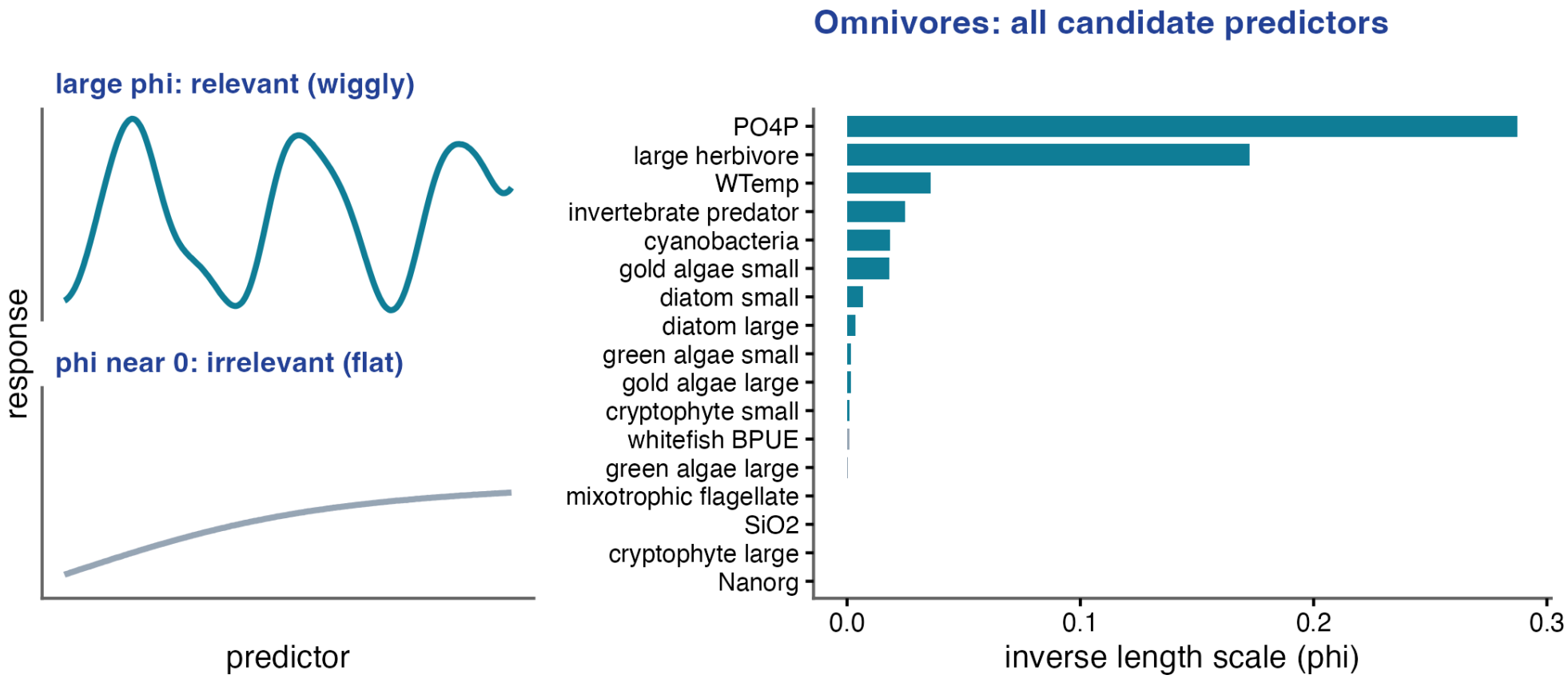
Gaussian process: no fixed equation



Next month = f(past states, drivers)

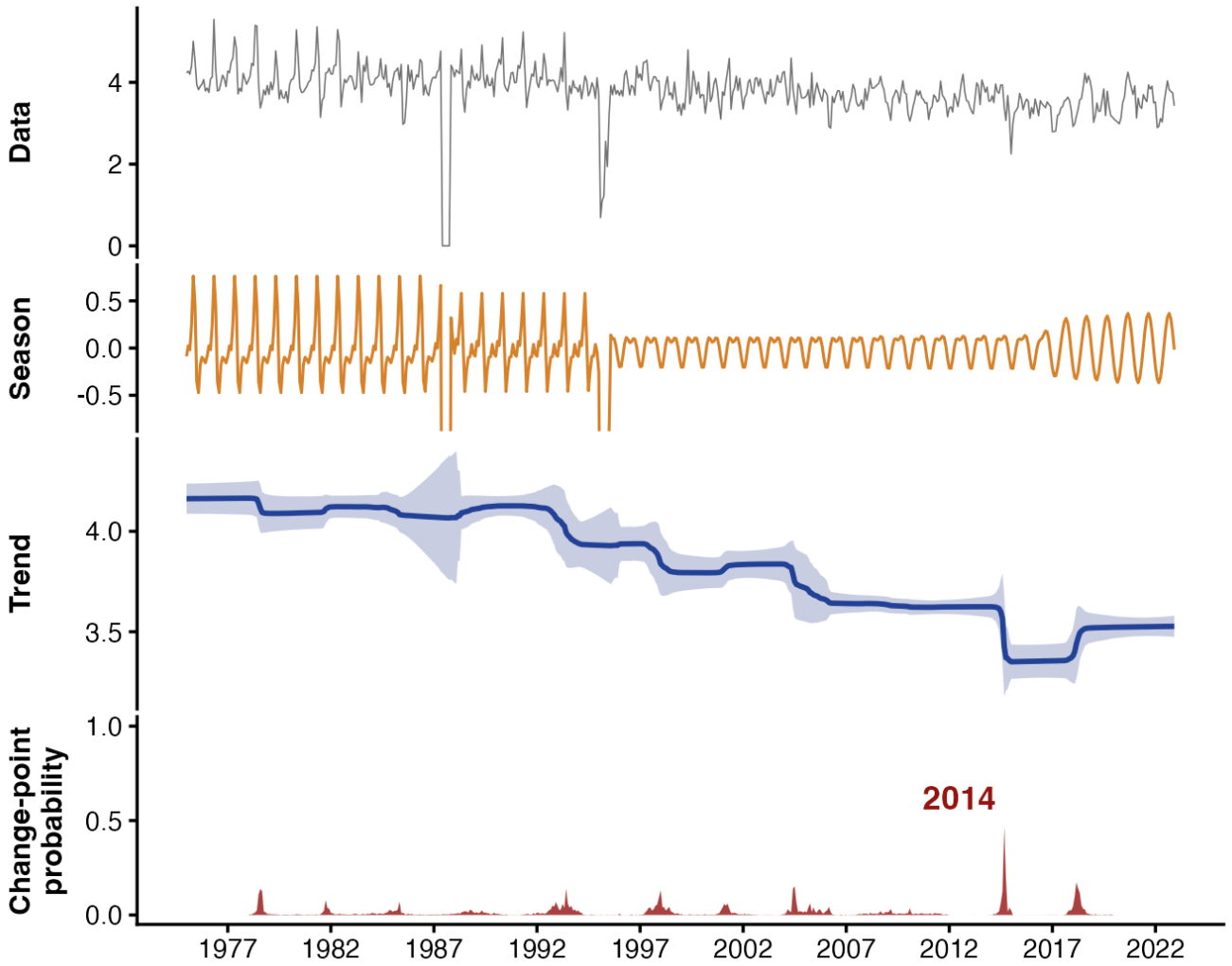
f learned from the data: Gaussian process

Automatic relevance determination (ARD)



One length scale per predictor: **phi near 0** = predictor dropped

What does BEAST do?



Splits the series

y_t = trend + season + noise

Finds change points

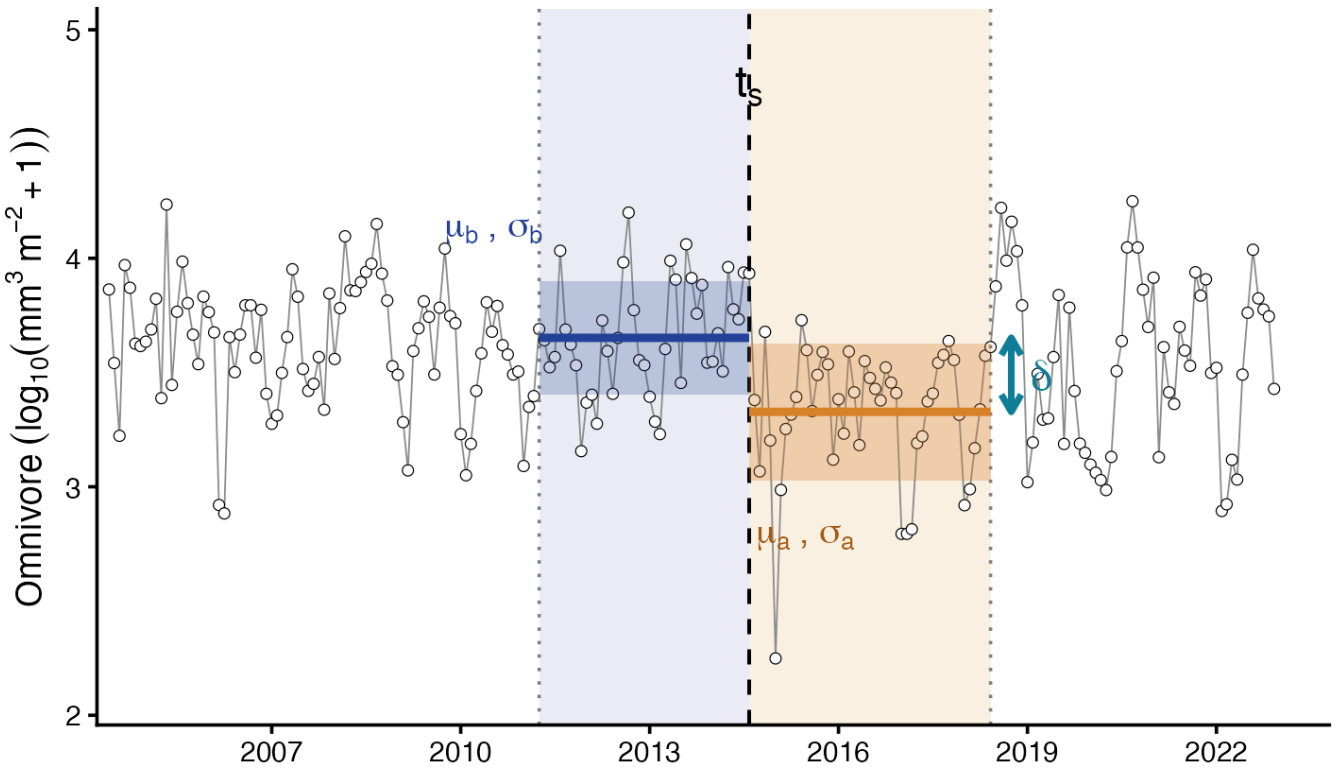
jumps of the **trend**

Gives a probability

Pr(change point) per month

Illustration: BEAST on the omnivores alone

Detecting regime shifts: criteria



1 Difference of the two chunks

$\delta = \mu_a - \mu_b \quad 0 \notin CI_{95\%}(\delta)$

CI = [0.19, 0.42] ✓

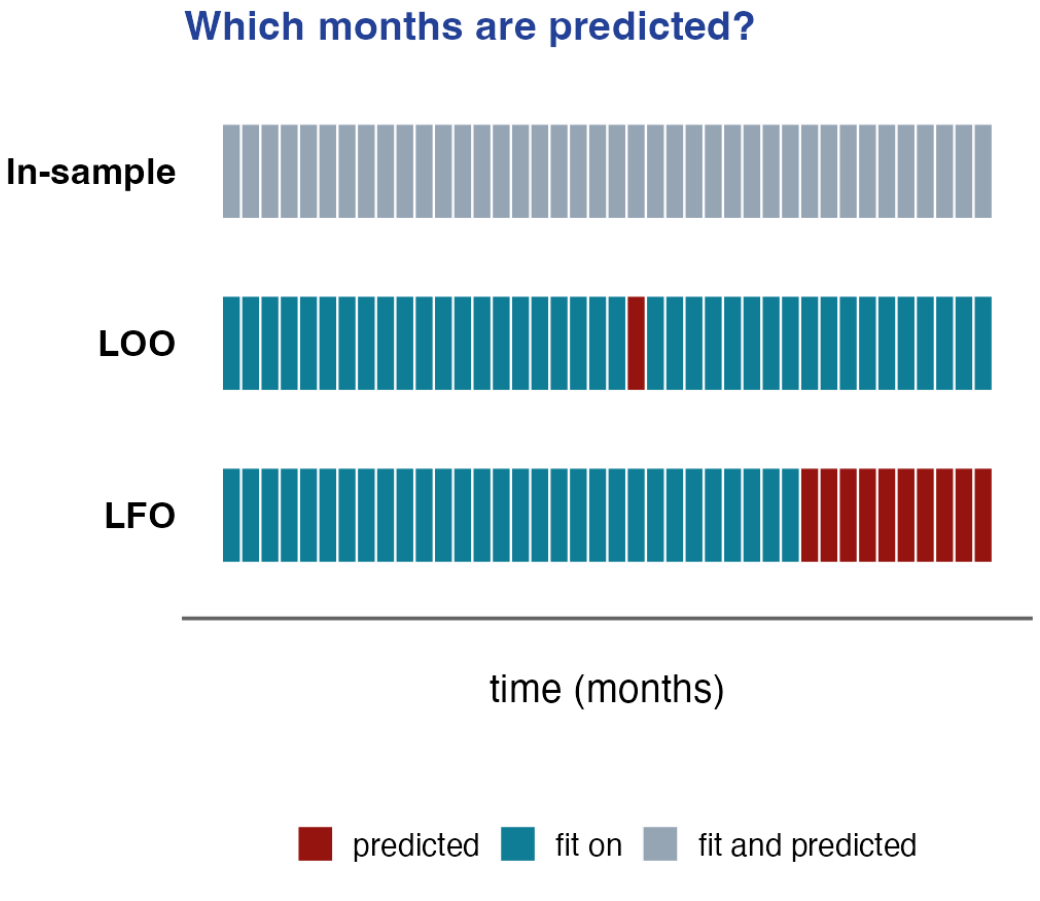
2 Abruptness: jump vs. usual swings

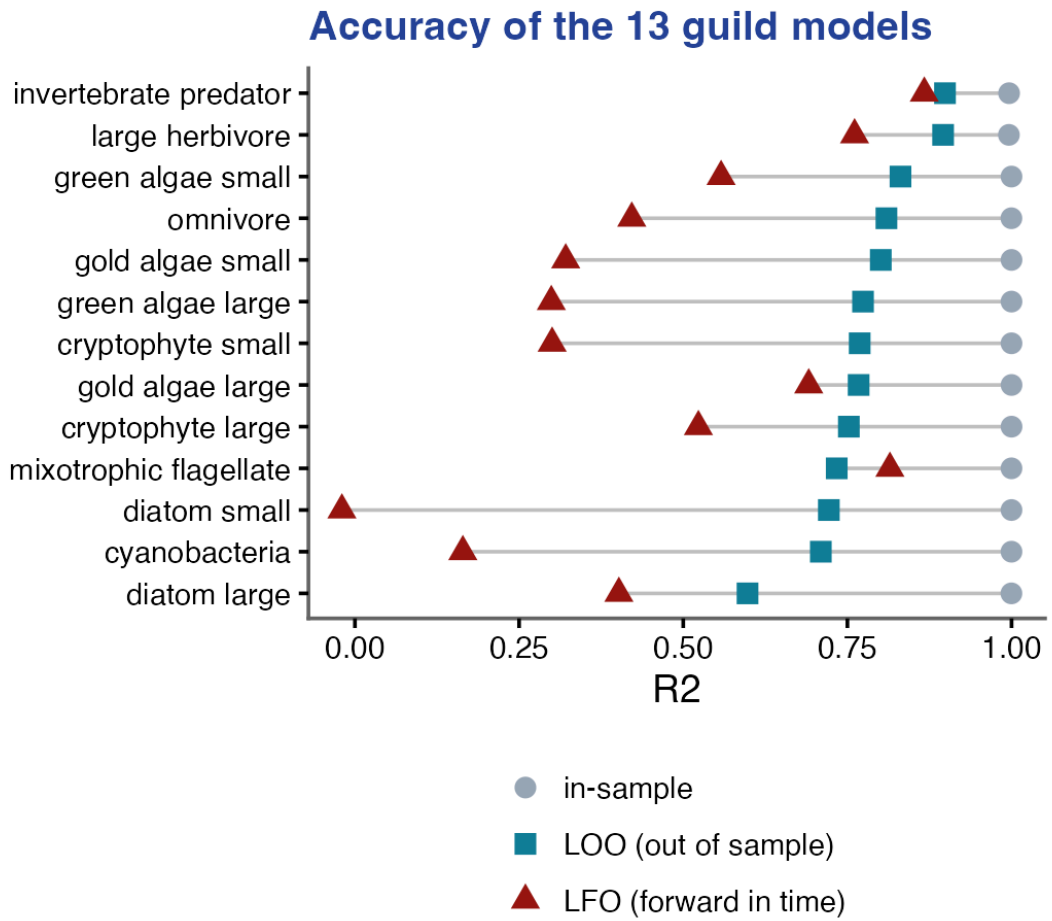
$$a = \frac{|\mu_a - \mu_b|}{½(\sigma_b + \sigma_a)} > 1$$

a = 1.19 ✓

Kept if 1 and 2 hold

In-sample versus out-of-sample R^2





In-sample: $R^2 = 1$, a GP interpolates

LOO: one month left out

LFO: forecast the last 10 %

Which genera? Zooplankton and mixotrophs



Invertebrate predators

Pr

Leptodora	73%
Bythotrephes	27%



Omnivores

Om

Cyclops	80%
Mesocyclops	17%
Acanthocyclops	1%
Thermocyclops	1%
Asplanchna	0%

+ 4 more



Large herbivores

He

Daphnia	91%
Eudiaptomus	6%
Bosmina	2%
Diaphanosoma	1%
Acanthodiaptomus	0%

+ 6 more



Mixotrophic flagellates

Mi

Ceratium	46%
Gymnodinium	45%
Peridinium	7%
other Flagellaten	1%
other Phytoflagellaten	0%

+ 14 more

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Which genera? Phytoplankton (1/2)



Cyanobacteria

Cy colonial

Anabaena	44%
Aphanizomenon	16%
Planktothrix	9%
Cyanothece	7%
Aphanothece	6%

+ 25 more



Green algae, small

Gr1 ≤ 550 µm³

Volvocales	30%
unidentified algae	24%
Chlorella	21%
Oocystis	7%
Characium	3%

+ 21 more

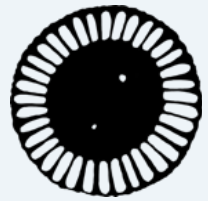


Green algae, large

Gr2 > 550 µm³ or colonial

other Chlorococcales	23%
Pandorina	18%
Mougeotia	16%
Chlamydomonas	10%
Ulothrix	6%

+ 46 more



Diatoms, small

Di1 ≤ 800 µm³

Stephanodiscus	81%
Cyclotella	17%
Achnanthes	1%
Fragilaria	1%
Nitzschia	0%

+ 9 more



Diatoms, large

Di2 > 800 µm³ or colonial

Fragilaria	50%
Stephanodiscus	15%
Asterionella	14%
Cyclotella	10%
Tabellaria	4%

+ 18 more

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Which genera? Phytoplankton (2/2)



Gold algae, small

Go1 ≤ 250 µm³

Erkenia	63%
Chrysochromulina	23%
Chromulina	4%
Ochromonas	2%
Pseudokephyrion	2%

+ 13 more



Gold algae, large

Go2 > 250 µm³ or colonial

Dinobryon	42%
Mallomonas	17%
Uroglena	12%
Chrysophyceae	12%
Pseudopedinella	6%

+ 9 more



Cryptophytes, small

Cr1 ≤ 700 µm³

Rhodomonas	99%
Plagioselmis	1%
Cyathomonas	0%
Cryptaulax	0%
Chilomonas	0%

+ 1 more



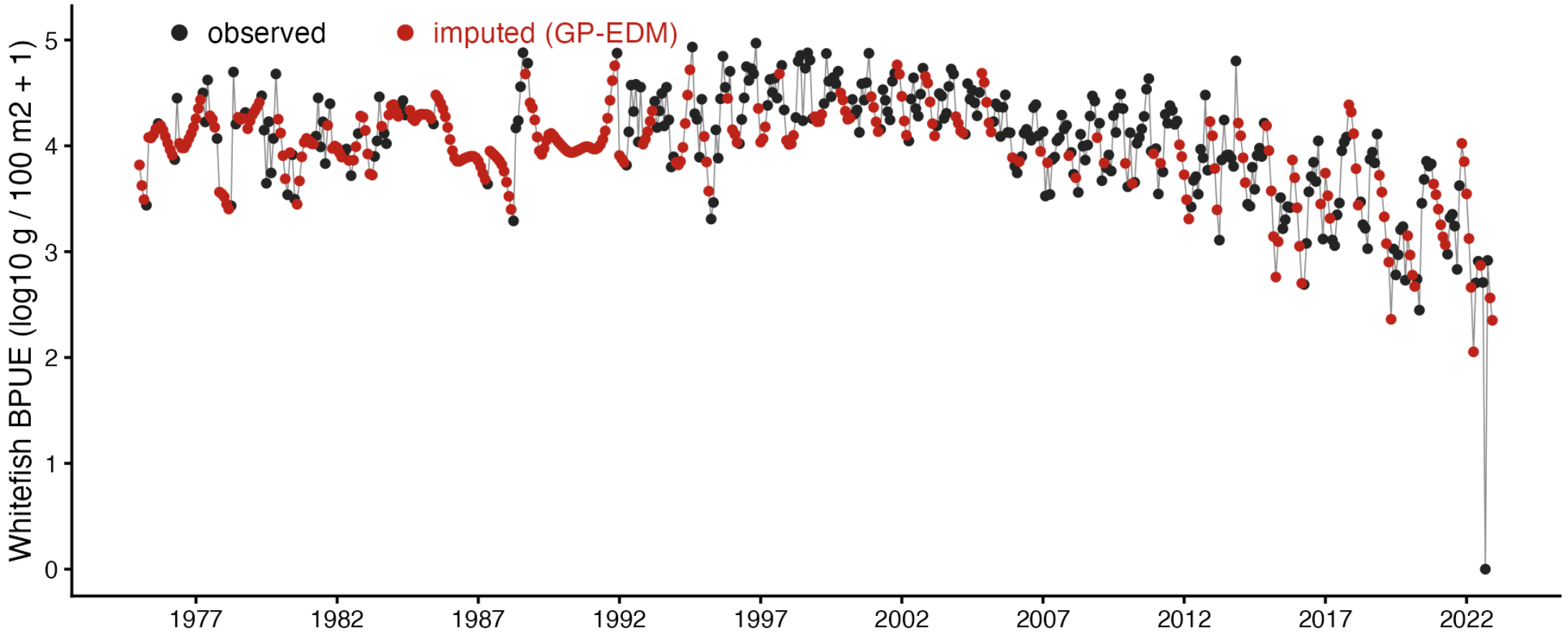
Cryptophytes, large

Cr2 > 700 µm³

Cryptomonas	100%
other Cryptophyceen	0%

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Whitefish time series: observed and imputed



287 of 576 months imputed (50 %)

GP-EDM, LOO R^2 = 0.55

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Lake Constance map (panel a): adapted from the published figure provided by the author. Panels b–d: IGKB monitoring data (phosphate, temperature) and IBKF whitefish catches, annual means 1975–2022.